

Measuring Rhetorical Alarmism in Disaster News: A Quantitative Framework Applied to the 2024 Valencia Floods

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June 1, 2026

Abstract

1 Introduction

The floods that affected the Valencia region in October 2024 have been described as one of the most severe natural disasters in recent Spanish history, resulting in 228 fatalities and affecting thousands of people. In such contexts of uncertainty and disruption, news media play a crucial role in society, as they are responsible for disseminating information and shaping how events are publicly interpreted (Pantti et al. 2012; Cottle 2014). For this reason, media coverage contributes to the construction of meaning around disasters, influencing not only how they are understood but also how they are socially and politically responded to.

Disasters are not only objective events defined by their material consequences, but also socially constructed phenomena influenced by the media representations (Pantti et al. 2012). The way in which different media outlets select, frame and narrate these events, plays a critical role in defining their salience, perceived severity, and broader social implications. Rather than acting as neutral transmitters of information, media operate as *'amplification stations'* of risk, intensifying certain aspects of the event while downplaying others, thereby influencing public perception and collective responses (Kasperson et al. 1988). This can be further understood through the framing theory, which posits that media do not simply report events but actively construct narratives by selecting, emphasizing and organizing specific aspects of reality (Scheufele 1999). Frames operate by defining problems, attributing causes and suggesting moral evaluations or potential solutions (Entman 1993).

However, the process of risk amplification is not neutral and may lead to distortions in how crises are represented and understood. In highly mediatized disaster contexts, the selection and intensification of specific elements can give rise to narratives that emphasize threat, urgency, and uncertainty in disproportionate ways (Cottle 2012). Holm in (Holm 2012) listed an excellent example of this phenomenon regarding the media coverage of Katrina Hurricane, the *New York Times* wrote: *"America is once more plunged into a snakepit of anarchy, death, looting, raping, marauding thugs, suffering infrastructure, a gutted police force, insufficient troop levels, and criminally negligent government planning"*. This is particularly evident in alarmist headlines, where linguistic and rhetorical choices tend to condense and dramatize complex events, often privileging emotionally charged interpretations over contextual nuance. As noted by (Molek-Kozakowska 2013), headlines work as strategic devices that package information, activate emotional and cognitive responses, and frame the audience's understanding of the event. As a result, media coverage may contribute to the construction of alarmist

narratives that frame disasters as unprecedented, uncontrollable, or escalating phenomena, potentially amplifying public fear and shaping collective responses beyond the immediate material impact of the event (Altheide and Michalowski 1999; Altheide 2018).

Despite extensive research on media framing and risk communication in the context of natural disasters, existing studies tend to approach *alarmism* in broad or implicit terms, without providing a systematic framework to identify and quantify it (see next section). In particular, while previous work has examined emotional framing, fear appeals, sensationalism, and media hype in crisis contexts, relatively limited attention has been paid to the specific rhetorical patterns through which alarmist narratives are constructed. Importantly, not all negatively framed or emotionally charged headlines can be considered alarmist, highlighting the need for a more precise conceptualization of this phenomenon.

This article addresses this gap by introducing the concept of *rhetorical alarmism* as a multidimensional form of media framing that operates through identifiable linguistic and narrative structures. Building on existing literature on framing and risk amplification, the study proposes a framework to systematically capture how media discourse constructs disasters as exceptional, uncontrollable, or escalating events.

Focusing on the case of the 2024 Valencia floods, the article aims to identify and quantify the presence of *rhetorical alarmism* in news headlines across different Spanish media outlets and social media platforms using an automated algorithm and an ad-hoc index, identifying statistical differences between media types, and examine the temporal evolution of the index.

2 Literature Review

2.1 Media Coverage in Natural Disasters

Media play a central role in shaping the public understanding of disasters, as well as in structuring broader aspects of social life. As argued by (Thompson 1995), the use of communication media transforms the spatial and temporal organization of social life, creating new forms of action and interaction while reconfiguring relations of visibility and power. In the context of disasters, this transformative role becomes particularly remarkable. Media do not simply transmit information about disruptive events, but actively participate in their social construction. In a globalized communication environment, disasters can no longer be understood as isolated or purely natural occurrences, but as phenomena deeply entangled with media and communication flows. In this sense, media increasingly “enter into” disasters, shaping them from both the *inside out* and the *outside in*, by reconfiguring social relations and infusing events with cultural and political meanings (Pantti et al. 2012).

2.2 A framework for Rhetoric Alarmism

3 Materials and Methods

3.1 Corpus Construction

This study analyzes a dataset of 1,347 headlines from different official news sources. The aim is to examine the presence of ‘alarmist’ framing in the coverage of the DANA event. The unit of analysis defined is the *journalistic headline* and in the case of social media, a sample for first *n-words* is taken from the post. The study period covers from 29th October to 30 November 2024, separating the data into two periods: the first from 29th October to 4th November (*Impact*), and the second from 5th November to 30th November (*Post*). This division allows for a comparative analysis of the framing used in the immediate aftermath of the DANA event and in the subsequent weeks.

To ensure an appropriate representation of Spanish media ecosystem, the corpus includes headlines from a variety of sources, which include national and local scopes. The data set includes headlines listed on the Table 1 3.1:

Media Type	Media Outlet
National Newspapers	<i>20 minutos, ABC, AS, EFE, El Mundo, El País EuropaPress, La Razón, La Vanguardia, Marca</i>
Local Newspapers	<i>Las Provincias, Levante EVM, El Mediterráneo, Torrent al día, Valencia Plaza</i>
National Radio	<i>La Cope, La Ser, Onda Cero</i>
Local TV	<i>7TeleValencia, À Punt, LaOchoTv</i>
National TV	<i>Antena 3, Telecinco, La Sexta, RTVE, Cuatro</i>
Social Media	<i>X, Facebook, Tiktok</i>

Table 1: Media outlets and social media included in the analysis

Data collection followed a reproducible procedure based on structured search queries. Whenever possible, the *Advanced Google Search Engine* was used, combining boolean operators and site domains. When this method was insufficient and provided poor results, internal search engines of media sites were used specifically in social media. A limitation was encountered in the case of *Instagram*, as the platform currently does not provide a reliable date-filtering mechanism comparable to search engines or other social media platforms such as *X* (Twitter). This constraint makes it difficult to reproduce the same sampling procedure, as result we decided to exclude this social media from the final corpus construction.

The general search pattern was as follows:

(dana OR "gota fría" OR lluvias OR torrenciales) AND Valencia AND 2024
site:<domain>

Explicit criteria were defined to ensure consistency across the headlines collected.

Inclusion Criteria

- Explicit reference to the phenomenon under study: DANA or heavy rainfall in Valencia
- Publication within the defined temporal window
- Headlines must originate from verifiable sources (URL or platform identifier)
- For social media: a minimum relevance threshold ($\geq 1,000$ interactions, such as likes or shares)

Exclusion Criteria

- Irrelevant or ambiguous content not directly related to the event
- Duplicated entries or republished content
- News outside the temporal scope
- Non-comparable formats, lacking a clean headline structure (except for social media)

The sampling strategy consisted of selecting up to 50 relevant headlines per media outlet, ordered according to their position in search results and filtered based on the inclusion and exclusion criteria defined previously. This approach was adopted to ensure a comparable sample size across outlets, preventing larger media sources from being overrepresented relative to smaller or local outlets, and thereby enhancing the consistency and reproducibility of the analysis. In cases where a given outlet did not reach the target sample size, all available headlines meeting the selection criteria were retained.

A limitation of this approach is that the first set of sampled headlines does not necessarily correspond to equivalent temporal windows across media outlets. Due to differences in publication intensity

over time, some outlets reached the target sample size more quickly than others. As a result, the collected samples may reflect not only outlet-specific framing strategies but also the natural temporal evolution of rhetorical alarmism.

Consequently, part of the observed differences in headline content may be driven by changes in the media discourse over time, rather than solely by differences between outlets. To address this issue, temporal variables such as time (in days) and coverage phase were incorporated into the statistical analysis. This allows for a more robust distinction between variations attributable to media-specific framing and those arising from the evolving phases of disaster reporting.

Following the data collection process, a structured database was constructed in which each observation corresponds to an individual headline. The final corpus comprises 1,347 headlines. For each observation, a set of variables was defined: the *media outlet* (source name), publication date, and the full headline text. Additionally, other categorical variables were incorporated, such as *media type* (e.g., press, radio, television, or social media) and the *temporal phase* of the event (impact or post-event stage). The dataset also includes an estimate of audience reach and the corresponding URL linking to the original content. The information related to audiences was collected from ...

3.2 Data Preprocessing

Text Normalization and Linguistic Processing

Prior to analysis, a text standardization process was applied to ensure consistency and reduce noise. The cleaning procedure included converting all text to lowercase, replacing punctuation with whitespace, collapsing multiple whitespace characters into a single space, and removing residual special characters. For social media content, additional preprocessing steps were implemented, including the removal of hashtags (#), mentions (@), emojis, and other non-linguistic symbols.

Once the text was normalized, all headlines were lemmatized to improve pattern detection. This process transforms each word (token) into its canonical base form, thereby minimizing the impact of inflectional variations such as verb conjugations, plural forms, and gender agreement. Lemmatization was performed using the UDPipe library (Straka and Straková 2017) with a Spanish pre-trained model (Taulé et al. 2008), which provides tokenization, part-of-speech tagging, and lemma extraction. Each headline was thus converted into a sequence of lemmas representing the original text. This lemmatized representation serves as the input for the subsequent regex-based detection process used to identify alarmist linguistic patterns.

Regex-based Algorithm for Detecting Rhetorical Alarmism

To classify news headlines according to the proposed framework, an automated algorithm was developed based on regular expression (*regex*) matching over lemmatized text. The construction of the regex patterns was guided by dictionaries associated with each of the four dimensions of *rhetorical alarmism* defined in this study. These dictionaries were manually elaborated and consist of keywords and linguistic expressions representative of each alarmism category. For each dimension, a set of regular expressions was generated to capture semantically and syntactically related patterns in the headlines. The algorithm evaluates each headline by matching its lemmatized tokens against the corresponding regex dictionaries. For every match, the associated alarmism category is recorded, the total number of detected alarmism categories is then computed for each headline.

To enable comparability across headlines of varying length, a normalized alarmism score is defined. Specifically, the number of detected alarmist patterns is divided by the total number of tokens in the headline, producing a dimensionless index of rhetorical alarmism (*RAI*). This normalization ensures that longer headlines are not systematically biased toward longer headlines, thereby allowing for fair comparisons across different media sources.

4 Conclusions

We conclude that....

External data

The experimental dataset is available at....

Funding

Acknowledgements

The authors wish to thank ...

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